



New faces, same old Australia

Australia's latest Women's T20 World Cup triumph showed that even in transition, the **game's greatest dynasty** remains the standard the rest are chasing.

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A bit anticlimactic, the ending was. No big six over the bowler's head. No sweetly timed cover drive, either. Not even a quick single.

Five wides.

That was how the 10th edition of the Women's T20 World Cup came to an end at Lord's on a sunny Sunday afternoon. Not that the Australian women would have complained. The individual glory of hitting the winning run did not matter to them.

For Australia, it marked the end of a long drought without a cricket World Cup. Its last one was in 2023. Three years may not seem like a long gap. But it is for this Australian team.

It is one of the greatest teams in history, not just in cricket but across all sports. It was even greater in the not-too-distant past, when it also had the likes of Meg Lanning and Alyssa Healy.

When you add players such as Ellyse Perry, Ashleigh Gardner, Beth Mooney, Tahlia McGrath and Megan Schutt, you get a team that belongs in the company of Clive Lloyd's West Indies cricket team, Dhyan Chand's Indian hockey team, the US men's basketball team at the 1992 Olympics, the US women's football team that won the 2019 World Cup and Pep Guardiola's Barcelona.

The thing about Sophie Molineux's Australian team is that it is in transition. It is never easy to

find replacements for players like Lanning and Healy.

Lanning is arguably the greatest batter of all time in women's cricket, while Healy is one of the most destructive the game has seen. She could impact a match with her strokes at the top of the order while also keeping wickets admirably. Phoebe Litchfield and Georgia Voll have come into the side and ensured that the runs continue to flow freely for Australia.

Voll had, in fact, been tipped by her opening partner, Mooney, to fire at the World Cup, but that didn't quite happen. Instead, it was Mooney who really fired. She was Player of the Final and the Player of the Tournament.

She had kept wickets beautifully during an England innings that never got going. A score of 150 for four was never likely to challenge an Australian batting line-up so strong and deep. So it proved. Mooney's 49-ball 64 took Australia almost home. When she departed, falling lbw to Sophie Ecclestone, only 14 were still required.

Gardner was on strike when Ecclestone bowled that wide, as Australia won by seven wickets with 2.5 overs to spare. At the non-striker's end was Perry. They hugged.

It was Perry's seventh World Cup triumph. The Australian women have now won seven of the 10 World Cups held in the T20 format. They were also the runners-up once. On the two remaining occasions, they reached the semifinals.

At the last edition, they were

knocked out by South Africa in the semifinals. They had the opportunity for revenge, as the Proteas were their opponents in the opening match. Australia won by 65 runs and followed it up with one dominant show after another: against Bangladesh (by nine wickets), the Netherlands (98 runs), Pakistan (113 runs) and India (six wickets). In the semifinals, it thrashed West Indies by eight wickets with seven overs to spare.

It was the Women in Blue who challenged them the most in England. Though Australia chased down the target of 171 with only an over remaining, the contest wasn't as close as the scoreboard would suggest. Perry and Gardner had batted India out of the match long before their 100-run partnership came to an end.

India had to win that match, the last in Group A. In what was very much the Group of Death, the fight for the second semifinal spot was between India and South Africa. The match between the two sides was, therefore, a potential quarterfinal. The Proteas won, riding on an extraordinary all-round performance from Marizanne Kapp.

It was a disappointing show from Harmanpreet Kaur's women. They had begun well, scoring expectedly easy wins against Pakistan and the Netherlands before running into South Africa, to whom they had lost 1-4 in an away series just a few months earlier.

After their historic victory at the ODI World Cup at home last year, expectations were high for the